Sharma said that Rabinder's betrayal haunted the R&AW for months. In the aftermath of his defection to the USA, the government initiated proceedings to remove his services under article 311 (2) (C) of the Constitution.

'Sometime in mid-May, the CIA station chief was summoned to find out whether the US government had been in the loop about Singh's recruitment and defection. We all knew that the CIA had done the job, but this was a procedural formality. As expected, the Americans feigned ignorance about Rabinder Singh and his wife and denied that any R&AW officer had been in touch with the US intelligence agency. The CIA personnel who had helped Rabinder and his wife, retired from the agency in 2012 after serving for almost twenty-six years and nowadays, he occupies a top position in an Arizona-based defence group,' Sharma told me.

After switching loyalties, Rabinder Singh settled in Florida. Since the R&AW and the CIA had a long-standing relationship and had collaborated on some major security events in the past, Rabinder Singh's defection was given a quiet burial for some time. But he wasn't forgiven. An encrypted message that was shipped through the diplomatic pouch from Washington in late 2016 confirmed that the double agent was dead. Further information revealed that Singh had died in a road accident in Maryland. It also came to light that after switching loyalties, Rabinder Singh lived as a refugee in the USA when the CIA dumped him months after the dramatic extraction to the USA via Kathmandu in May 2004. He had been beset with financial problems since the CIA had stopped sending him pay cheques and his attempts to get a job at a think tank run by a former CIA deputy director were stonewalled, pushing him into a deep depression. A remorseful Singh, burdened with the sin of